

What are Russia and China signalling in the Bering Sea?

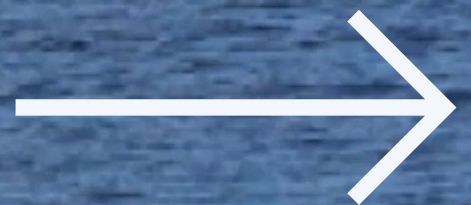


Photo: China Coast Guard

Since 2022, Russia and China have sharply increased joint naval, air, and coast guard exercises in the North Pacific.



Exercises are signalling tools

- They serve symbolic as well as material purposes.
- They convey intentions, commitments, or warnings to influence the behaviour of other states or actors.
- They are public, intentional, and sometimes costly.



Russia signals

- its great-power status,
- willingness to counter U.S./NATO operations,
- desire to maintain relevance in the Arctic after its isolation post-Ukraine.



China signals

- status as a maritime great power (海洋强国) with far-sea operational capabilities,
- push back against U.S. “island chain” containment,
- desire to avoid being excluded from the Arctic.



Read full article

Lamazhapov, E. & Østhagen, A. (2025). "China, Russia, and the U.S. in the Bering Sea." *Arctic Yearbook 2025*.

